Pulakeshin who was the Shiva-worshipping builder of Cave 1 and its prototype Nataraja.

From Badami, this prototype Lord of the Dance seems to have moved north, to the Ellora Caves and Elephanta. However, the later Early Chalukyas under the most successful of their rulers, the illustrious Vikramaditya II, avenged his forefathers by defeating their ancient enemies the Pallavas and taking over their capital at Kanchipuram, where he recorded his victory in Kannada on a pillar in the main hall of its Kailasanatha temple, dated to the year 732. A second Chalukyan incursion followed in 744, so presumably it was at this time that the concept of Shiva Nataraja migrated south to take root in Pallava country.

Recent studies have shown that the Shiva Nataraja's transmogrification from stone into metal may not have taken place under the Cholas, as previously thought, but by their southern vassals, the now weakened Pallavas. This is not to deny the Cholas credit for taking over this casting technique from the Pallavas and raising it to heights of perfection previously unknown in India, resulting in some of the most breathtaking works of religious art ever created. These Chola Natarajas were made to be seen. Although installed in the dark recesses of temples they were brought out daily and regularly conveyed in procession through the surrounding streets to the sound of music and drum. It can be argued that the elevation of Lord Shiva by his followers in the Tamil South to a position of supremacy within the Hindu pantheon went hand in hand with the promotion of Shiva Nataraja under the Cholas as the very embodiment of Chola supremacy, no longer frenzied as in the earlier stone carvings but as a calm, controlling ruler at the centre of a whirling cosmos.

Shiva Nataraja as we know him today owes a lot to the efforts of two early promoters of Indian art: the British art historian Ernest Havell, who first came out to India in 1884 to manage the Madras School of Art, and the Ceylon-born